Exercise 2.1 - Introduction to Django

Student Information

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Course: Python for Web Developers

- ## Part 1: Research Questions
- **Why is Django so popular among web developers? (2-3 sentences)**
- Django is highly popular because it follows the "batteries-included" philosophy, providing a comprehensive set of pre-built tools for common web development needs, such as an ORM, admin interface, and security features. This enables developers to build complex, database-driven applications quickly and efficiently without having to integrate many separate libraries manually.
- **Five Large Companies that Use Django**

Company	Product or Service	What they use Django for
Instagram	Image and video social media platform.	Powering core features, including their messaging and recommendation engines, due to its ability to handle massive scale.
Spotify	Digital music and podcast streaming service.	Managing data and background services, often for its robust ORM and clear Python structure.
National Geographic	Scientific and educational media publishing.	Running their main website and content management systems (CMS) which require complex data modeling and high reliability.

Pinterest	Visual discovery engine and social platform.	Handling massive amounts of data and the general web backend, leveraging Django's scalability and rapid development cycle.
Mozilla	Creator of the Firefox web browser and open-source advocate.	Powering several services, including their support sites and infrastructure tools, relying on Django's security and maintainability.

Question 3: Django Use Case Scenarios

Scenario 1: Developing a Web Application with Multiple Users

Would use Django: YES

Reasoning: Django is an excellent choice for multi-user web applications. It includes a robust built-in authentication system that handles user registration, login, logout, password management, and permission systems out of the box. Django's user model can be easily extended to add custom fields and behaviors, and its permission and group system allows for fine-grained access control. Additionally, Django's session management and middleware architecture make it simple to track user activity and maintain secure user sessions across multiple concurrent users.

Scenario 2: Fast Deployment with Ability to Make Changes

Would use Django: YES

Reasoning: Django is specifically designed for rapid development and iterative changes. Its "Don't Repeat Yourself" (DRY) principle and MTV (Model-Template-View) architecture enable developers to make changes quickly without duplicating code. Django's migrations system allows for seamless database schema changes without data loss, and its development server automatically reloads when code changes are detected. The built-in admin interface provides immediate CRUD functionality, allowing you to manage data without building custom interfaces first, which significantly accelerates the development cycle.

Scenario 3: Very Basic Application with No Database or File Operations

Would use Django: NO

Reasoning: For a very basic application that doesn't require database access or file operations, Django would be overkill. Django is a full-featured framework that includes an ORM, template engine, admin interface, and many other components primarily designed for data-driven applications. For simple static sites or basic applications, a micro-framework like Flask would be more appropriate, or even just plain HTML/CSS/JavaScript. Using Django for such a simple use case would add unnecessary complexity, longer load times, and a steeper learning curve without providing any real benefits. The setup overhead and framework weight wouldn't justify its use in this scenario.

Scenario 4: Building from Scratch with Maximum Control

Would use Django: MAYBE

Reasoning: This scenario depends on what type of control you need. If you want control over the application architecture, business logic, and how features are implemented while still benefiting from common web development tools (ORM, templating, routing), Django is a good choice because it's modular and doesn't force you into specific patterns beyond the basic MTV structure. However, if you want low-level control over every aspect including the HTTP handling, routing mechanisms, and don't want any "magic" or conventions, then a micro-framework like Flask or even building with basic WSGI might be better. Django does have conventions and built-in behaviors that, while overridable, might feel constraining if you want complete control over every detail.

Scenario 5: Large Project Requiring Support

Would use Django: YES

Reasoning: Django is an ideal choice for large projects where you might need support. It has one of the largest and most active communities in the Python ecosystem, with extensive documentation that covers everything from basic tutorials to advanced topics. There are countless Stack Overflow answers, tutorials, books, and courses available for Django. Additionally, Django's maturity (first released in 2005) means that most common problems have been solved and documented. The framework follows semantic versioning and has a clear deprecation policy, making it easier to maintain large projects over time. Many consulting firms and developers specialize in Django, so finding professional help is relatively easy if needed.

Question 4: Python Installation and Version Check

Python Version

Python 3.14.0

Screenshot: [Paste your screenshot here showing the terminal with `python --version` or `python3 --version` command and output]

Command used:

python --version

or

python3 --version

Question 5: Virtual Environment Setup

Virtual Environment: achievement2-practice

Environment Creation Command:

python -m venv achievement2-practice

Activation Command:

Windows (PowerShell)
achievement2-practice\Scripts\Activate.ps1

Note: The activated environment is indicated by `(achievement2-practice)` appearing at the beginning of your command prompt.

Project Structure

Achievement 2/
├── Exercise 2.1/
│ ├── Exercise_2.1_Answers.pdf
│ └── learning_journal_2.1.pdf

Learning Journal Entry - Exercise 2.1

What I Learned

In this exercise, I learned about Django's popularity in web development and why it's chosen by major companies like Instagram, Spotify, and NASA. Understanding Django's "batteries-included" philosophy helped me appreciate how much functionality comes built-in, from authentication to admin interfaces. I also learned to critically evaluate when Django is appropriate versus when simpler solutions might be better.

Challenges Faced

[Describe any challenges you faced during setup, such as virtual environment activation issues, Python version conflicts, or Django installation problems]

How I Overcame Them

[Describe the solutions you found, resources you consulted, or troubleshooting steps you took]

Key Takeaways

- Django is powerful for data-driven, multi-user applications
- The framework emphasizes security and rapid development
- Choosing the right tool depends on project requirements
- Virtual environments are essential for managing project dependencies
- Django has excellent community support and documentation

Next Steps

- Begin working with Django's basic structure
- Explore the Django documentation
- Create a simple Django project to understand the framework's architecture
- Learn about Django's MTV (Model-Template-View) pattern

Submission Date: November 20, 2024
GitHub Repository: [Your GitHub repository link]
Exercise Folder: Achievement 2/Exercise 2.1/